

they saw tremendous scope in the 'offshore outsourcing model' to help global companies reduce time to market and address the skill gap in developing software solutions. They also founded InfoAxon Technologies UK (a 100 per cent subsidiary of InfoAxon Technologies), and began software development using .NET technology for clients like Virgin Media.

Within a year, things began to work well for InfoAxon, which was looking at creating a niche for itself within the software development market. "We had existing customers inviting us to a huge opportunity emerging in the UK public sector. One of our initial customers – the London borough of Camden – was involved in a project funded by the Office of the Deputy Prime Minister (ODPM), which was working towards making all government services available online through a series of projects named the 'Pathfinder' projects. To make that happen, local authorities in UK needed a content management (CMS) and knowledge management solution (KMS). No proprietary solution fitting the exact need for ODPM projects was available to the public sector back then. They had two options – to either customise a proprietary solution or go for open source technology. Realising that the former carried the risk of vendor lock-in, the deputy PM's office decided to support the open source project, APLAWS (Accessible Personalised Local Authority Web Sites - <http://www.aplaws.org.uk>). The London borough of Camden, Red Hat and InfoAxon were involved in the project from the start. This marked the beginning of our open source voyage," says Nagar.

InfoAxon focused on the core architecture of the APLAWS platform and some of its key contributions included the form builder; the ability to go to the main CMS and create dynamic forms; plug-ins for HTML, news feeds and RSS feeds; a design of the front end CMS layer, etc., which were all path breaking at that time. This is also when InfoAxon, as a company, became entirely convinced about the open source business model.



Shubham Nagar, chief executive officer, InfoAxon Technologies.

The early setbacks

However, despite an easy start, selling open source at a time when awareness levels were low wasn't easy. InfoAxon had to battle mindset issues at a time when proprietary software was the *de facto* choice. "The initial sales cycles were very long. We had to dedicate substantial time in presentations to explain what open source was, as most customers didn't understand the model. Thereafter, a lot of information exchange needed to be done to ensure the client remained convinced. Thus, we spent a lot of time and energy in pre-sales legwork. Despite that, many a time, it wouldn't convert into engagements," recalls Vineet Dahiya, co-founder and director, InfoAxon Technologies. "However, this is changing rapidly now, as there are proven open source success stories in almost every field of IT and the industry verticals. Now, there is less open source evangelism required during our discussions with customers. Instead, they straight away engage us in understanding the value we provide to them using open source as a model for innovation. This suits us completely, as we have a wealth of open source expertise and experience and are able to demonstrate our value quite early on, leading to quick engagements," adds Dahiya.

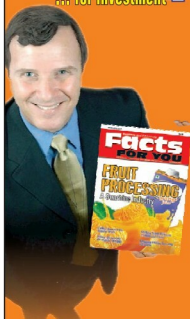
Charting out a new route to success

The strategy of selling a 'complete solution' rather than open source, per se; of looking at every customer as a stream of opportunities/ revenue; and using existing customers as doors to reach out to new clients, helped

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